Lesson 34: Project: Tell an Anecdote or a Personal Story

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 4: Education and Creativity

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 4.6: Unit Project Option 1 - Tell an Anecdote; 4.7: Unit Project Option 2 - Tell a Personal Story.

In this lesson

This is the final project of Unit 4. You choose one option: tell an anecdote, or tell a personal story about a memorable experience. You plan and write your story, then tell it to your AI tutor (2-3 minutes) and record yourself with your phone. You use the pronunciation from this unit: -ed endings, connected speech and thought groups.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Name the four parts of an anecdote and find them in a story.
- Plan a story with notes: who, what, when, where and why.
- Tell a 2-3 minute story in the past tense with correct -ed endings.
- Mark -ed endings, connected speech and thought groups in your own transcript.
- Record yourself and check your speech with the book's rubric.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
anecdote	a short, funny or interesting story; usually something surprising happens, and the speaker often learns something	Sir Ken Robinson tells an anecdote about Gillian.
background information	Who? When? Where? The place, the time and the people	Gillian's school told her mother that Gillian had a learning disorder.
set-up	the part where the problem starts (sometimes with a possible solution)	Gillian's mother took her to a special doctor.
surprise	something unexpected that happens	What was the surprise in the story?
lesson (moral)	the important thing we learn from the story	What can we learn from the story?
memorable (experience)	special, so you remember it well (something that happened to you)	One of my most memorable experiences in Thailand was ...
rough draft	the first version of your writing; you will improve it	Write a rough draft of your story.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
transcript	the written words of your speech	Include a transcript.
visual	a picture or slide that helps people understand	Include a visual that will help us understand your story.
connected speech	joining words together when you speak	I traveled a lot. (travel-da lot)

Rules and explanations

Two options

- **Option 1: Tell an anecdote.** Tell a short story about a memorable experience in which you or someone you know learned something. Include all four parts of an anecdote. The book says this option is for stronger students.
- **Option 2: Tell a personal story.** Talk about a memorable experience you have had. Answer these questions: What happened? Who was involved? When and where did the story happen? Why was the experience memorable? If you need more support, choose this option.
- For both options: speak for 2-3 minutes from memory, use the past tense, mark a transcript, and show a visual. (See "Writing task".)

The four parts of an anecdote

1. **Background information:** Who? When? Where? (the place and the people)
2. **The set-up:** the problem starts, and sometimes a possible solution is presented.
3. **The surprise:** something surprising or unexpected happens.
4. **Lesson or moral:** the story ends, and we usually learn something important from it.

Pronunciation to use (review of this unit)

- **-ed endings:** /t/ after an unvoiced sound (watched), /d/ after a voiced sound (played), /ɪd/ after /t/ or /d/ (visited). See Lesson 32.
- **Connected speech:** link a final consonant to a vowel at the start of the next word: at a school (a-ta school). See Lesson 29.
- **Thought groups:** pause between thought groups and stress one focus word in each group. See Lesson 33.

How to mark your transcript

- Write /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/ above each -ed verb.
- Draw a curved line under two words that you link.
- Draw a / between thought groups, like the book's example: I was hired to teach English / at a school in Thailand / from 2008-2009. / While I was there, / I traveled a lot.

Practice

1. Study Sir Ken Robinson's anecdote. Watch the Gillian Lynne story again (15:19 to 17:29, see "Watch online"). Write the main idea of each part in a few words. Then complete the table in your own words.

- Background information: Gillian's school told her mother that Gillian had a learning disorder. (book)
- The set-up: Gillian's mother took her to a special doctor. The doctor listened to the problem. Then he turned on some music and asked Gillian's mom to leave the room with him. They left Gillian alone in the room with the music. (book)
- The surprise: ?
- The lesson: ?

2. Study the teacher's example. Read Brittany's story about the Tiger Temple in your printed lesson (4.7, "Transcript").

- a. Find all the -ed verbs. Write /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/ for each one.
- b. The first sentences (to "with waterfalls") already have / between thought groups. Continue with the next three sentences.
- c. Find two places where a final consonant links to a vowel.
- d. Answer the questions: What happened? Who was involved? When and where did it happen? Why was it memorable?

3. Choose your option and topic. Choose an everyday experience, for example: your first day at a new job or school; learning to drive or to cook a dish; a trip to a new city; a day you got lost; a problem with a car, a phone or a bus, and how you solved it; a time a neighbor or a stranger helped you.

4. Brainstorm. Make notes (not full sentences).

- Option 1: What happened? Who was involved? When and where did the story happen? What was the problem? What was surprising? What did you learn from this experience?
- Option 2: What happened? Who was involved? When and where did the story happen? Was there a problem? Did anything surprising happen? Why was the experience memorable? Did you learn anything from the experience?

5. Write, mark and practice. Write your rough draft (see "Writing task"). Mark the transcript. Practice telling the story many times until you can say it with only a few notes.

6. Tell and record. In Live conversation, tell your story to your tutor. At the same time, record a video of yourself with your phone. Show your visual. Speak loudly and look at the camera.

7. Check yourself. Watch your video and give yourself points with the book's rubric (60 points). Each part gets 10 (excellent), 7 (good), 5 (needs improvement: record again) or 0 (no marks: record again). For 10 points:

- **Content:** Option 1: a memorable experience where someone learned something, with all four parts. Option 2: all five questions answered (who, what, when, where, why).

- **Organization and clarity:** well organized, interesting and clear.
- **Delivery:** loud enough; you look at the camera; you know most of it from memory and use notes only a little.
- **Pronunciation:** very clear; you use most -ed endings, connected speech and thought groups correctly.
- **Visual:** a picture that helps the story.
- **Transcript:** all -ed endings, connected speech and thought groups are marked correctly.

Speak with your tutor

- "I want to tell a story about [my topic]. Ask me the questions one at a time: What happened? Who was involved? When and where? Why was it memorable? Help me make short notes."
- "Listen to my anecdote. Then tell me: did it have all four parts, background, set-up, surprise and lesson? Which part needs more detail?"
- "I will tell my story again from memory. Stop me if you do not understand a sentence."
- "Ask me two thoughtful questions about my story, like a classmate who watched my video."
- "Tell me a short anecdote about a surprising day. Then I will ask you two questions about it."

Writing task

Write a rough draft of your story.

- **Option 1 (anecdote):** include the four parts: background information, set-up, surprise, lesson.
- **Option 2 (personal story):** answer all the questions: What happened? Who was involved? When and where did the story happen? Why was the experience memorable?
- Use the past tense and some of the -ed verbs from this unit. Check every verb.
- Make it long enough for a 2-3 minute talk. Read it aloud and time yourself with your phone.
- Turn it into your transcript: mark the -ed endings (/t/, /d/, /ɪd/), linked words and thought groups (/).
- Choose a visual: a picture or a slide that helps listeners understand your story.
- Read the draft to your tutor and ask it to correct your past tense verbs before you record. Then memorize the story.

Watch online

- TED Talk "Do Schools Kill Creativity?", the Gillian Lynne story (watch 15:19 to 17:29): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iG9CE55wbtY&t=919s
- Transcript of the TED Talk: https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity/transcript

Answer key

1. (example answer) The surprise: the doctor and Gillian's mother watched her from outside, and Gillian immediately started to dance to the music. The doctor said: "Gillian isn't sick. She's a dancer. Take her to dance school." The lesson: different people learn in different ways; some people need to move in order to think. Gillian went to dance school and became a very successful dancer.

2. a. hired /d/, traveled /d/, visited /ɪd/, played /d/ (two times), watched /t/, realized /d/, wanted /ɪd/, decided /ɪd/. (went, swam, ate, brought, gave, took and spent are irregular.) b. (example answer) One of my most memorable experiences in Thailand / was when I went to Kanchanaburi / and I visited the Tiger Temple. / The Tiger Temple is a place / where monks have taken in tigers / to protect them from poachers. / I went to the Tiger Temple / with a friend. c. at a school (a-ta school); swam in (swa-min); brought out (brough-tout); spent a year (spen-ta year). d. (book) She went to the Tiger Temple in Kanchanaburi, played with baby tigers, gave them milk and baths, took a tiger for a walk and took pictures. She went with a friend. It was in Thailand, when she taught English there (2008-2009). It was memorable because she had the opportunity to spend time with real tigers.

3.-7. Your own work. Ask your tutor to check it.

Example anecdote (example answer, about 100 words; your 2-3 minute talk needs more details): *Background:* Last winter, my brother and I traveled to a small town in the mountains. *Set-up:* On the second day, our car stopped on a quiet road. We tried to call for help, but our phones had no signal, so we decided to walk. *Surprise:* After ten minutes, an old farmer stopped his truck and offered to help. He fixed our car in five minutes and invited us to his home for tea. He refused to take any money. *Lesson:* I learned that a bad day can become a good memory, and now I always try to help people on the road. -ed verbs: traveled /d/, stopped /t/, tried /d/, decided /ɪd/, offered /d/, fixed /t/, invited /ɪd/, refused /d/, learned /d/.

My notes